

Chinchilla lanigera

Chilean chinchilla



Location S.W. South America

Length 8–9½ in (22–24 cm)

Tail 5–12½ in (13–32 cm)

Weight 14–18 oz (400–500 g)

Social unit Group

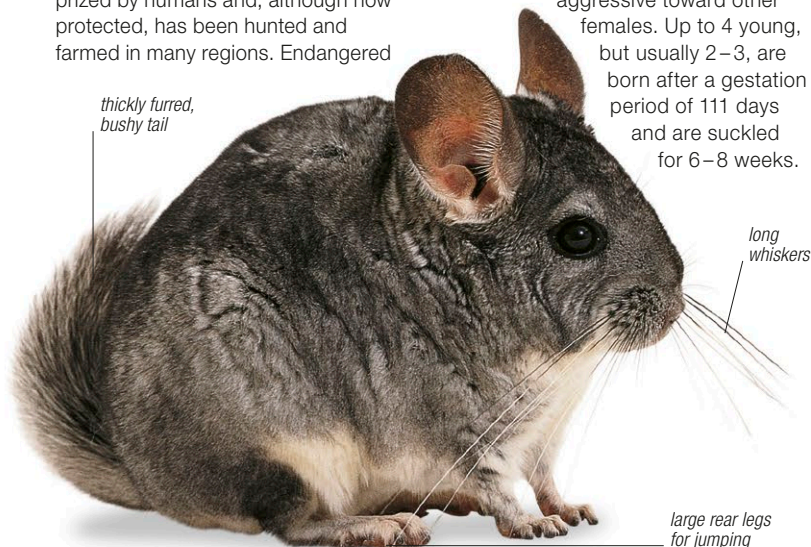
Status Endangered



This rodent's thick, soft, silky fur, which keeps out the bitter cold of its mountain habitat, has long been prized by humans and, although now protected, has been hunted and farmed in many regions. Endangered

in the wild, the Chilean chinchilla is common as a pet, with its appealing appearance and usually friendly nature. The fur is silvery gray-blue above and cream or yellowish on the underside, with long gray and black hairs on the tail's upper surface. In the wild, the long-tailed chinchilla forms colonies of 100 or more in rocky areas, sheltering in caves and crevices. It eats most plant foods, especially grass and leaves, sitting up to hold items in the front feet while watching for danger. If threatened, it rears up and spits hard at the aggressor. During the winter breeding season, the female, which is larger than the male, becomes more

aggressive toward other females. Up to 4 young, but usually 2–3, are born after a gestation period of 111 days and are suckled for 6–8 weeks.

*Octodon degus*

Common degu



Location S.W. South America

Length 6½–8½ in (17–21 cm)

Tail 3¼–5½ in (8–14 cm)

Weight 7½–11 oz (200–300 g)

Social unit Variable

Status Least concern



Resembling a very large mouse, this mountain-dwelling rodent has a stout body. Mainly brown, it has pale underparts, and there may also be yellow furry "lids" above and below each eye, and a yellow neck ring. The long tail, which has a tufted black tip, breaks off easily if grabbed by a predator. The common degu lives in colonies and excavates extensive burrow systems. It feeds by day on a varied diet of plant matter and, in the dry season, cattle droppings. It stores excess food in the burrow for winter.

Myocastor coypus

Coypu



Location S. South America

Length 18½–23 in (47–58 cm)

Tail (13½–16 in 34–41 cm)

Weight Up to 14 lb (6.7 kg)

Social unit Group

Status Least concern

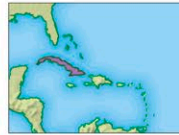


The coypu or nutria was farmed for its dense brown fur, but escapees established colonies in many areas outside its native region. It has a large head, small, high-set eyes and ears, a robust body, arched hindquarters, long, rounded tail, and webbed rear feet for rapid swimming.

The coypu eats most vegetation, especially water plants, and lives in bankside tunnels in family groups.

*Capromys pilorides*

Desmarest's hutia



Location Caribbean

Length 12–24½ in (30.5–62.5 cm)

Tail 5–12½ in (13–32 cm)

Weight 10–15 lb (4.5–7 kg)

Social unit Individual/Pair

Status Least concern



Desmarest's hutia resembles a huge vole with its typically blunt nose, large head, short neck, small ears, stocky body, and short limbs. It has a white nose, red-brown to black upperparts, and gray or yellow-brown underparts.

The strong, tapering, hairy tail and sharp, curved claws are adapted for support and gripping when tree climbing and when foraging for its varied diet of fruit, leaves, soft bark, and, occasionally, lizards. Litter size is 1–4. Hutias live only in the Caribbean, and most species are either severely threatened or already extinct.

*Heterocephalus glaber*

Naked mole-rat



Location E. Africa

Length 2¾–4¼ in (7–11 cm)

Tail 1¼–2 in (3–5 cm)

Weight 1¼–2¼ oz (15–70 g)

Social unit Group

Status Least concern



This mole-rat's social system is unique among mammals. Only one dominant female, the "queen," breeds. She may have more than 1–28 pups per litter and is tended by several nonworkers.

The colony's workers form head-to-tail "digging chains" to tunnel and gather food. The naked mole-rat is not truly naked but has pale, sparse hairs over its pinkish gray skin. As in other mole-rats, the massive incisor teeth are for digging and eating, and the eyes and ears are minute. The tail is rounded and the limbs strong, with 5 thick-clawed toes, for digging. Colonies comprise 40–80 individuals that inhabit elaborate tunnel systems. Food-gathering galleries 6–20 in (15–50 cm) deep radiate up to 130 ft (40 m) from the central chamber. New galleries are dug regularly for roots, bulbs, tubers, and other underground plant parts. This rodent surfaces only to travel to another colony.

*Cryptomys hottentotus*

Hottentot mole-rat



Location Southern Africa

Length 4–7¼ in (10–18.5 cm)

Tail ¾–1¼ in (0.8–2.7 cm)

Weight 3¾–5½ oz (100–150 g)

Social unit Group

Status Least concern



This mole-rat has a wide head, small eyes and ears, short, sturdy limbs, stocky body, and thick, dense fur. Coloration is pink-brown or gray above, with paler underparts. Extra-large incisor teeth bite through soil as well as bulbs, tubers, roots, and other subterranean plant parts. Colonies of 5–15 individuals dig large, complex tunnel systems and store excess food. Usually only the senior pair breeds.

Bathyergus janetta

Namaqua dune mole-rat



Location S. W. Africa

Length 7–9½ in (17–24 cm)

Tail 1½–2½ in (4–6.6 cm)

Weight 7–25 oz (195–710 g)

Social unit Variable

Status Least concern



This species tunnels in shifting sands, either on the coast or inland. It lives in small colonies in a tunnel system up to 655 ft (200 m) long. The large head has massive protruding incisor teeth, the body is cylindrical, the legs are short but strong, and the tail is tiny. The back is dark brown, the sides gray, and the head and belly dark gray.